Brig KPN Singh could not have been more perceptive. I think I learnt more from Brig Sandhu than from Brig KPN Singh. Brig Sandhu would make us explain the logic behind every recommendation, backed by sound facts and figures. Whereas Brig KPN Singh had mothered us, Brig Sandhu made us really do the staff work that was expected of us. When we went around for the first operational familiarization, Brig Sandhu asked the officers and JCOs all sorts of questions. What is the name of that feature or how wide and deep is this rivulet and such like. Quite often the personnel present there would not know the answer and Brig Sandhu would turn to me with an inquiring look. Thanks to the three weeks I had spent familiarizing myself (on Brig KPN Singh's orders) I could reply positively to almost all queries. Brig Sandhu quickly realized that I was not some desk-bound staff officer but knew my beans, all thanks to Brig KPN Singh. After that, I could do no wrong as far as Brig Sandhu was concerned. During the familiarization, Brig Sandhu had often saddled up on a mule for some of the steeper climbs. I would walk up by the shorter route and be waiting for him at the top. He would often refer to me as a goral (a type of mountain goat that was found in the area).

The goral was almost the cause of our undoing. Seeing the difficult terrain, we had projected the requirement of a motorable track so that vehicles could ply up and down, making the administration of these far-flung and isolated posts that much easier. However, for the project to go through, we needed the clearance of the Principal Conservator of Forests (PCF), whose office was in Jammu. This was just not forthcoming, citing the disturbance and ecological impact that it would have on the goral population in the area. Brig Sandhu knew better than to fight this red tape. Instead, he asked me to organize a picnic near these posts and invite the PCF for a fun day out.

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